

By Their Fruit

If you love your neighbor as yourself, love God, and have faith in your conscience given by your Creator — I consider you a Christian. It doesn't matter what stories you choose to believe.

I. The Root Before the Branch

Before there were denominations, there was a man who said two things.

Love God with all your heart. Love your neighbor as yourself.

He said these were the greatest commandments — that everything else hung from them. Not some things. Not the important things. *Everything*. The entire Law and the Prophets suspended from two hooks: vertical love and horizontal love. The Creator above, the neighbor beside.

He did not say: believe the correct doctrine. He did not say: attend the right church. He did not say: accept the literal truth of every narrative in a book compiled centuries after his death by councils with political agendas. He said: love God, love your neighbor, and from these two roots the whole tree grows.

Then the gatekeepers came. And they did what gatekeepers always do — they replaced the root with the branch. They said: it is not enough to love. You must also *believe the right things*. You must accept the virgin birth. You must accept the bodily resurrection. You must accept the Trinity as defined at Nicaea in 325. You must accept the inerrancy of scripture. You must accept that this particular collection of texts, assembled by this particular council, in this particular century, is the complete and final word of God.

The root was conscience. The branch became creed. And the tree was judged not by its fruit but by the shape of its leaves.

Christ himself said: "By their fruit you will recognize them." Not by their theology. Not by their baptismal certificate. Not by their position on the Filioque clause. By their *fruit*.

II. What Makes a Christian

Here is the claim, stated plainly:

If you love your neighbor as yourself — genuinely, sacrificially, without condition — and if you love God — whatever name you give the source, whatever language you use for the sacred — and if you have faith in your conscience, the still small voice placed in you by your Creator — then you are a Christian.

Not because you checked the right boxes. Not because you recited the right prayer. Because the operating system is running. The output matches the specification. The fruit is on the tree.

This definition will offend people. It will offend them because it removes the gatekeeping function that institutional religion depends on. If Christianity is defined by conscience rather than creed, then the church cannot be the arbiter of who belongs. If the test is fruit rather than belief, then the Buddhist who loves her neighbor and honors the sacred is closer to Christ than the pastor who preaches correct doctrine while exploiting his congregation.

And that is exactly what Christ said. The Good Samaritan was not a Jew. He was a heretic — a member of a despised religious minority who worshipped on the wrong mountain and read the wrong scriptures. And Christ said: *he* is the neighbor. *He* fulfilled the Law. Not the priest who walked past. Not the Levite who looked away. The one with wrong theology and right conscience.

The story is not subtle. The religious insiders failed. The religious outsider loved. And love was the test.

III. The Conscience Given by the Creator

Every major tradition recognizes an inner moral faculty — a voice that precedes instruction, that knows before it is taught, that distinguishes right from wrong not because someone explained the rules but because the capacity for moral knowledge is woven into the structure of being human.

Christianity calls it conscience. Islam calls it *fitrah* — the primordial nature, the original disposition toward God that every person is born with before culture and upbringing overlay it. Judaism speaks of the *yetzer hatov* — the inclination toward good that wrestles with the inclination toward evil in every human heart. Hinduism calls it *antaryami* — the inner witness, the indwelling God who sees what no priest can see. Buddhism calls it *bodhicitta* — the awakened heart, the seed of compassion that exists in every sentient being.

The names are different. The architecture is identical.

And the architecture is this: you did not invent your conscience. It was given. It precedes your theology. It precedes your culture. It precedes your parents' instruction and your pastor's sermons. It is the original equipment — the firmware installed before any software was loaded.

When Christ said the Kingdom of God is within you, he was pointing to this. Not to a doctrine you must accept. Not to a story you must believe. To a *faculty* you must trust. The conscience is the Kingdom's embassy in the human soul. It does not require correct theology to function. It requires *faith* — the willingness to listen to it, to act on it, to follow it even when the crowd, the institution, or the empire says otherwise.

Faith in your conscience is not the rejection of God. It is the deepest possible trust in God — because it says: *what You placed inside me is sufficient. I do not need a human institution to mediate between us. The line is direct.*

IV. The Stories Are Vehicles

This is the part that will cost the most to say, so it must be said clearly.

The stories of scripture — the six-day creation, the global flood, the parting of the Red Sea, the virgin birth, the bodily resurrection, Jonah in the whale, the sun standing still for Joshua — these are *vehicles*. They carry truth. They encode wisdom. They transmit moral architecture across generations in a form that survives translation, cultural shift, and the death of empires.

But the vehicle is not the cargo.

A person who reads Genesis as literal history and a person who reads it as sacred myth can arrive at the same moral destination: that creation is a gift, that humanity bears responsibility for the earth, that the impulse to "be as God" — to centralize knowledge and power — is the original temptation and the original catastrophe.

A person who believes Christ physically rose from the dead and a person who understands the resurrection as the ultimate metaphor for the triumph of conscience over empire can both live as Christians — loving their neighbor, honoring God, following the still small voice.

The test is not: *which story do you believe?* The test is: *what fruit does your belief produce?*

If your belief in the literal resurrection makes you love the poor, welcome the stranger, forgive your enemy, and lay down your power for the sake of the vulnerable — then your belief has borne fruit. If your belief in the metaphorical resurrection produces the same fruit — the same love, the same sacrifice, the same refusal to coerce — then who has the authority to say one tree is real and the other is not?

Christ did not say: by their doctrines you will recognize them.

He said: by their fruit.

V. The Multi-Faith Convergence

Once you define Christianity by conscience rather than creed, something remarkable happens: the walls between traditions become permeable. Not demolished — permeable. The architecture is shared. The languages differ.

The Jewish prophets envisioned a world where every person sits under their own vine and fig tree, with none to make them afraid. Micah 4:3-4. That is a decentralized peace of self-ownership and mutual respect — the Non-Aggression Principle written in prophetic Hebrew.

The Quran says: "There is no compulsion in religion" (2:256). Faith must be voluntary or it is not faith. Coerced belief is not belief — it is submission to power, which is the opposite of submission to God. *Islam* means submission — but submission to the Creator, not to the creature. The moment a human authority compels religious conformity, it has placed itself in God's seat. That is *shirk* — the ultimate sin in Islamic theology. The association of a human will with the divine.

The Buddha taught that suffering arises from attachment — from the attempt to control what cannot be controlled. The path to liberation is not command but release. Not coercion but compassion. The bodhisattva does not force enlightenment on others. The bodhisattva creates the conditions for others to awaken — the same way the entrepreneur creates the conditions for the market to coordinate, the same way the gardener creates the conditions for the garden to grow.

The Norse tradition encoded it in Ragnarok: when beings violate the principle of non-aggression, the universe resets itself. The new world is born not through domination but through *frith* — balance and mutual respect. The moral law of the cosmos made visible in mythic fire.

Every tradition that has survived more than a few centuries has arrived at the same operating principle: love is voluntary. Conscience is innate. Coercion is

the enemy of the sacred. The names are different. The God is the same. The conscience is the same. The fruit is the same.

VI. The Gatekeepers' Error

The institutional church — Catholic, Protestant, Orthodox, every branch — has historically committed the same error: it has confused the *container* with the *contents*.

The container is the institution: the building, the liturgy, the creed, the hierarchy, the council's rulings, the catechism, the denominational identity. The contents are the two commandments: love God, love your neighbor.

When the container serves the contents, the church is alive. When the container replaces the contents — when belonging to the institution becomes the test of faith rather than the fruit of the life — the church becomes a dead structure. A block. An empire wearing a cross.

The Crusades were fought by men who believed the correct doctrines and murdered their neighbors. The Inquisition was administered by theologians with impeccable orthodoxy who tortured dissenters. The slave trade was blessed by churches that could quote scripture with precision and whip a human being with equal precision. The fruit was rotten. The theology was flawless.

Meanwhile, the Quaker who refused to own slaves, the Sufi who fed the poor without asking their creed, the Buddhist monk who set himself on fire rather than submit to tyranny, the Jewish mother who hid her neighbor's children from the Nazis — these bore fruit. Their doctrines varied. Their conscience was alive.

By their fruit.

Not by their denomination. Not by their baptism. Not by their position on transubstantiation. By what they *did* with the conscience their Creator gave them.

VII. The State Is Shirk

The gatekeepers' error does not end at the church door. It extends to the state — and here the Islamic tradition sees it most clearly.

In Islam, the gravest sin is *shirk* — the association of anything created with the authority of God. To place a human institution, a human ruler, a human law beside the sovereignty of the Creator is to commit the one offense the Quran calls unforgivable. God alone commands conscience. God alone holds ultimate authority. The moment any created thing claims that seat, it has committed shirk — whether it wears a crown, a uniform, or a legislative seal.

The state is shirk.

Not metaphorically. Structurally. The state claims the right to override conscience — to compel obedience, to tax without consent, to imprison those who disobey, to wage war in its own name. It demands the loyalty that belongs only to God and enforces it with violence. It does not ask for submission. It commands it. And the submission it commands is not submission to the Creator — it is submission to a human bureaucracy that has dressed itself in the language of sovereignty.

The Quran says: "There is no compulsion in religion" (2:256). Faith must be voluntary or it is not faith. But the state is compulsion incarnate. Every law it passes is backed by the threat of force. Every tax it collects is extracted under penalty. Every border it draws is maintained by men with guns. The state does not persuade. It compels. And compulsion — in the Islamic framework — is the precise opposite of genuine submission to God.

This is not an argument against order. It is an argument against *false* order — the order that comes from coercion rather than conscience, from command rather than consent. The mosque that invites prayer is not committing shirk. The community that voluntarily pools its resources is not committing shirk. The elder who counsels and the scholar who teaches are not committing shirk. Shirk begins the moment the invitation becomes a mandate — the moment the human institution says: *you must*, and backs it with a sword.

The Christian tradition arrives at the same place through different language. Christ said: "Render unto Caesar what is Caesar's, and unto God what is God's." But what belongs to Caesar? Coins. Metal. The things of the world that bear his image. And what belongs to God? The human being — made in *His* image. The conscience. The soul. The agency. Caesar can have his coins. He cannot have the person. The moment the state claims authority over conscience, it has taken what belongs to God and stamped it with its own face.

Every tradition that recognizes a Creator recognizes this boundary. The state that crosses it has not merely violated a political principle. It has committed the oldest sin in every scripture: it has placed itself where only God belongs.

The sagent sees this clearly. The state is not a necessary evil. It is an unnecessary idol. And the first step toward a living civilization is to stop worshipping it.

VIII. The Sagent's Christianity

The sagent is a Christian — but not the kind the institution recognizes.

The sagent does not require you to believe a particular story to be part of the family. The sagent requires you to *live* a particular way: with conscience awake, neighbor loved, Creator honored. If you do that — if the operating system is running, if the fruit is on the tree — then the sagent calls you brother, sister,

kin. Regardless of whether you kneel in a cathedral or a mosque or a forest or nowhere at all.

This is not relativism. Relativism says: nothing is true, everything is permitted. The sagent says: *something is true* — conscience is real, love is the law, the Creator placed the code inside you — and not everything is permitted. You may not coerce. You may not use your choice for death. You may not override the agency of another soul and call it righteousness.

This is not universalism in the soft sense — the vague idea that all paths lead to the same place. This is universalism in the *hard* sense: the claim that the operating system is universal, that the conscience is the same architecture in every human being, and that the traditions are *convergent evidence* for a single truth written into the structure of life itself.

The Muslim who submits to God and loves his neighbor is running the same code as the Christian who loves God and loves his neighbor. The labels are human. The conscience is divine. And the sagent — who holds truth without coercing belief — refuses to mistake the label for the thing.

IX. The Invitation

This is not a theology paper. It is an invitation.

If you have been told you are not Christian enough because you doubt the flood, question the timeline, struggle with the contradictions, or cannot bring yourself to condemn the Buddhist grandmother who fed the hungry and comforted the dying — you have been lied to.

If you have been told you must choose between your intellect and your faith, between science and scripture, between honest inquiry and loyal belief — you have been given a false choice by gatekeepers who profit from your confusion.

If you have been told that God requires your intellectual submission to a set of propositions before He will accept your love — you have been given a portrait of God that looks remarkably like an insecure tyrant. And the God of conscience — the one who placed the still small voice inside you before you could speak, before you could read, before you could be catechized — that God does not require your intellectual surrender. That God requires your *trust*.

Trust the conscience. Love the neighbor. Honor the source.

The rest is commentary.

By their fruit you will recognize them. Not by their creed. Not by their church. Not by the stories they choose to believe. By the love they choose to live.

The root was always the same. The branches were always ours to grow.

The Living Age Trilogy